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ENG382 - Reflective Essays

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Essay 1: Imagine in detail the kind of workday (or just “day”) you’d like to have a year hence. Five years hence. Ten years.

In one year, I will be 5 months post-grad. At this point, I would like to have a job or at least a paid internship. Ideally, I’d be living at home on Long Island and commuting either locally or into Manhattan. I would like a position working in communications or technical writing. In this entry level position, I’d like to continue developing the software skills I have learned in the PWTC program. I want to continue learning and improving in Madcap Flare and in HTML. In five years, I’d like to be living in a city, either Boston, New York, or Raleigh. I’d commute to work via walking or the subway and be working in content strategy or technical writing. My ideal workday would be to work 9-5 Monday-Friday, Friday would be hybrid. I’d like to be in a team environment that works on interesting and advanced projects for a client base. By this point, I want to be proficient in Madcap Flare and learning more necessary software such as Figma or Hootsuite. In ten years, I will hopefully be at a team leader position. I want to move forward from staff technical writer or content writer and into a more senior position. I will have learned how to lead and manage a team effectively. I would like to work mostly remote or hybrid, commuting into a physical office when necessary. I would also like to branch into other parts of the company, possibly into marketing or digital advertising. In ten years, I would like to have been with a company for at least 3 years. I want to be able to grow and learn in the same environment after gaining the necessary experience in other positions. My ultimate long-term goal is to be a senior staff member or director of my branch, managing teams and projects effectively.

Essay 2: Enumerate the reasons you chose your course of study (major and, if appropriate) minor or specialization.

During my time at UMass, I have majored in English, gotten a certificate in Professional Writing & Technical Communication, and will finish my Information Technology minor next semester. I chose to become an English major because I felt that writing was my strongest skill. I knew I wanted a career in which I produced public-facing content, yet I wasn’t sure what specific job I wanted. Originally, I was a linguistics major and hoped for a career in computational linguistics. I quickly learned this field was not for me, and that is when I found the PWTC program while researching an English degree. PWTC promoted all of the technical skills I knew I wanted while also allowing me to strengthen my skills as a writer. I wanted to be

able to work with software alongside writing content, and this program was a perfect blend of both worlds. I chose to pursue an Information Technology minor to further round out the technical aspect of my resume. I was able to take two coding classes and get a certification in computer competency. I wanted to have a tech aspect to my resume because I wanted to be able to work in many different fields, as well as make myself as hireable as possible. Having a background in coding helps to emphasize my skills in critical and strategic thinking. Through the English major and PWTC program, I was exposed to so many different types of writing that I found I enjoyed. Nonfiction writing is something that I had never even considered before becoming an English major, and now it is a possible career path for me. What surprised me most about becoming an English major was just how versatile the degree is, especially combined with the certification and minor I chose. I have the skills for multiple different positions and I am excited to see what roles I am able to fill.

Essay 3: Describe your relationship to technology in general or specific terms. You may consider how you read on electronic devices; how you write with software, how you use social networking sites. You may gain a focus here by considering your own history – as the first software program you learned, your first experience with YouTube or Twitter, etc.

Although part of my childhood existed in a world without smartphones, I have little to no memory of it. As a very young child, I remember putting VHS tapes in to watch Disney movies and having a DVD player for the car. I also remember having an iPad in elementary school and an iPhone in middle school. Technology has always been a part of my life and was an integral part of my development. I grew up on the internet, making friends over Instagram and posting videos to TikTok (formerly Music.ly). To look back at the relationship I have with technology is interesting, because it has since become the foundation of global culture. As a child I remember talking to peers about the shows we watched on TV, the commercials that came on after, or the movies we saw in theatres. In the era of cable television, everyone watched the same show at the same time. We all had the same thing to talk about at the lunch table the next day. Now, there are millions upon millions of videos uploaded to Instagram and TikTok every day. I find myself in the middle of extremely heated discourse within a niche community of people obsessed with a show I've never even heard of. Modern social media has brought us infinitely closer together. I can send my friends abroad TikToks and Instagram reels from thousands of miles away, and we text like there's no distance at all. It brings the people who are closest to me, even closer. However, the people I don't know, it pushes even further. It is much more difficult to connect with the strangers around me if I have a community already on my phone. As someone who briefly remembers life before social media, the difference in human connection between then and now is incredibly interesting to witness.

Essay 4: Reference what you thought when you thought about your career and/or life five and ten years hence and consider whether any of the guest speakers made you rethink or change those expectations.

After listening to the guest speakers that spoke to our class, I find that a lot of my predictions for myself were fairly accurate. Many of the speakers are remote workers and are members of teams that work on audience facing material. Many of them also began as entry level associate employees who moved up in titles as they gained experience. I am hoping to be able to follow their lead and find positions similar to them. I also think that becoming a team lead is a very possible goal to reach. Many of the speakers are leaders, managers, and senior members of their teams. It was incredibly inspiring to hear success stories of people who have the exact same training I have. It was also very comforting to hear that fellow English majors and PWTC grads are hireable and successful. Their advice was invaluable to someone entering the workforce, and their connection could get me a job some day. Additionally, I believe that it is imperative that I live in or near a city. Despite most speakers being remote, they all lived in or around a large city. While I had planned for this originally, seeing the locations of the speakers solidified that I can't move to the middle of nowhere and must stay within traveling distance of the office. Many of the speakers mentioned using Madcap Flare, which is also something I thought I would have to continue using. Although sometimes it frustrates me, I am grateful to have a foundation in Madcap Flare that I can use in my beginning roles which will hopefully make it easier for me to learn the software quickly. The speakers also mentioned using other types of software I had never heard of before, but I found it useful to know so that I can learn it before I graduate in December.

Essay 5: Describe the manner in which your final project for this course relates to a special interest, combines aspects of your skills and knowledge, and/or (if applicable) prepares you for further work or study in a given field.

My final project focuses on AI and the job market. This interest is not exactly special, but does matter to me as I prepare to graduate in December. I have been applying to a lot of internships over the last year, and have been looking at jobs I hope to begin applying to in the fall. In my final project, I discuss how AI has changed the hiring process. I found the research I did incredibly enlightening and relevant to me as I apply for internships and come into contact with AI hiring systems. I have completed an AI hirevue interview, which I didn't find out was reviewed by AI until months after I was rejected. I was under the impression a real person would be reviewing the video I sent in, but apparently it was reviewed by AI. I'm not sure if that knowledge would have changed anything had I known prior, but it should have been made clear by the employer. This project has also allowed me to strengthen my experience with AI, as I was actively analyzing their responses. I try not to use AI for anything other than grammar checking, so it was interesting to interact with it for a specific purpose and be able to fully dissect its work. I feel that the experiment I conducted was useful for interacting with AI, as that is something I will definitely have to do

in the future. It was also helpful to research and gain knowledge in AI and data centers. AI is not going away and will become an integral part of my future. Every speaker that came to class mentioned using AI and how it is being pushed by employers, so I am grateful to have a lot of knowledge and some experience with it before applying to jobs that expect me to use it.